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SCI FI TECH

April 26, 2007 Circulation: n/a

DreamAuthentics Katana: Arcade-style gaming on Atkins

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What kid hasn't dreamed of having a huge arcade-game cabinet all to himself? Of course, when you finally have the means to actually live the dream, the prospect of a huge stand-up console in your apartment probably doesn't look as attractive as it did when you were 12. But what if there were a way to relive your junior-high afternoons racking up points on Time Pilot without adding an extra bedroom for the hardware?

DreamAuthentics' Katana machine is made for folks who want a taste of old-school arcade fun without the bulk. Fitting reasonably well on a desktop, the Katana looks like a junior version of an arcade console, sporting a 17-inch flat display and classic joystick/button controls. The cabinet is built around a Windows PC with DA's proprietary software package that includes over 200 arcade classics like Dig Dug and 1942 as well as titles from the Atari 2600. There's also a jukebox application that mimics the look and flavor of the type you'd find in your neighborhood pub, controlled by authentic buttons on the front.

Follow the link for my hands-on impressions and pics of the Katana along with pricing information.

Although it seemed a bit weird at first to be sitting in front of an arcade console, I got used to it pretty quickly. The games themselves are pretty much 100% accurate (It's been a while since I played Gauntlet, but I've still got it!), although I found the screen to be a tad small, especially for 2007. The jukebox app is great, expertly simulating barroom machines — I wish iTunes had an option to work this way.

I had two issues with Katana, though: To accommodate games like Defender, the console actually has a lot more buttons than you expect, leading to at-times confusing controls. Second, the control panel flips up to provide access to the PC inside, and it tends to come loose during moments of intense gameplay — something all too common with arcade-style play. The DreamAuthentics people assured me there would be a latch of some kind in production models.

Speaking of those, Katanas will be available for all starting in May for $2,495 each. A little bit extra and they'll customize the cabinet for you. — Peter Pachal